

PRINT CULTURE
'Residency Reversed' by Gulammohammed Sheikh (etching-aquatint, 1983)

Pushpamala N. has known Gulammohammed Sheikh for close to half a century now. The 89-year-old artist, art historian and writer, after all, was also her professor at the Faculty of Fine Arts in Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda in the 1970s. One would imagine that those many decades of knowing and observing someone in their closest quarters would leave little room for surprise. But Sheikh had a big one up his sleeve for Pushpamala, the curator of his latest retrospective at TRI Art and Culture Gallery in Kolkata, titled *Hand Prints / Mind Prints*.

It's an ongoing two-part exhibition of Sheikh's lifelong fascination with printmaking, which has remained relatively unknown to his audience. The artist has remained unfazed by that. "Well, it's not that my prints were not shown, but they were shown in either some shows of printmaking or in group shows. They were not picked out especially to project that aspect," he says. "My printmaking was generally known among printmakers, perhaps, and among some artists, but not everybody."

Part one of the show, *Hand Prints*, is laid out like an archive, tracing Sheikh's handmade print practice from the 1950s to the present, and includes his woodcuts, linocuts, etchings, aquatints, lithographs and silkscreens. It also examines his prolific involvement with magazines as a means of democratising art and ideas, with the handwritten school journal *Pragati* (1952), the avant-garde literary journal *Kshitij* (1957–63) and *Vrishchik* (Scorpio, 1969–73), which he co-founded with Bhupen Khakhar.

"When he started showing me the little magazines, I got really excited because they became my entry point into this entire body of 70 years of handprints," Pushpamala says about her chance encounter with this part of his repertoire only as recently as 2023. "From the 1950s to the 2020s, he had been working across different printmaking processes, and what struck me was

▶ EXHIBITION

Remote Renaissance

AN EXHIBITION OF **PAHARI PAINTINGS** IN WASHINGTON DC OFFERS VISITORS AN OPPORTUNITY TO REDISCOVER A RICH ARTISTIC TRADITION

In the foothills of the Himalayas, between steep valleys and scattered princely kingdoms, a remarkable artistic tradition flourished for centuries. Delicate, luminous and emotionally charged, Pahari paintings remain among the most captivating achievements in Indian art. Now, a major exhibition at the Smithsonian Institution's National Museum of Asian Art in Washington DC is bringing these extraordinary works into renewed focus. Titled *Of the Hills: Pahari Paintings from India's Himalayan Kingdoms*, the exhibition features 48 paintings and coloured drawings, including several works never before publicly displayed.

Created between the 17th and 19th centuries in the hill kingdoms of the Himalayas, Pahari paintings are celebrated for their vivid colours, poetic

ARTISTS USED OPAQUE WATER-COLOUR FROM PIGMENTS, GOLD AND EVEN BEETLE WINGS TO CREATE RADIANT SURFACES



